been under detention without charge for a number of years because of their suspected attachments to communism.'[15]

Despite some similarities, Bhagat Singh's case, however, stands in many ways in stark contrast to the Meerut Conspiracy Case, which began in camera on 15 March 1929. The district magistrate of Meerut issued warrants for the arrest of the accused. Langford James, the special prosecutor, opened the case before the magistrate on 12 June 1929. The accused were committed to trial by the sessions court on 13 January 1930. The trial was scheduled to be heard before a judge, accompanied by five assessors. At that stage, on 31 January 1930, the applications for a trial by jury had already been rejected by the chief justice of the Allahabad High Court. But it then took until 17 January 1933 for the judgment to be delivered.

Thereafter, the appeal was determined by the high court in a judgment some six months later on 13 August 1933. Importantly, the charge in that case was also 'conspiracy to deprive the King Emperor of his sovereignty of British India'. The government fielded 320 prosecution witnesses in the magistrate's court. In the sessions court, there were 281 prosecution witnesses. There was a mountain of documents to get through. The charge was that the accused had entered into a conspiracy to further the objectives of the Communist International in Moscow. However, in that case the accused consisted of some of the most eminent leaders of the communist and trade union movement in India, such as S.A. Dange, Muzaffar Ahmad, S.V. Ghate, S.S. Mirajkar, Sohan Singh Josh, M.A. Majid and P.C. Joshi. They also included three Englishmen: Philip Spratt, Benjamin Bradley and Lester Hutchinson. But the difference with the Lahore Conspiracy Case lay in the fact that the Meerut Prisoners' Defence Committee was formed largely through the efforts of Jawaharlal Nehru. His father Motilal Nehru was the chairman of the Meerut Prisoners' Defence Committee. Bizarrely, there was no such person or counsel of national eminence involved in the Lahore Conspiracy Case. The Lahore High Court Bar protested vigorously and the accused themselves were contemptuous of the maverick way in which the legal procedures were used against them. Unlike Bhagat Singh,